



OFF-SIDE

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THE TYRANNY OF TIME

From Kohli and Djokovic to Messi and Ronaldo, sport's greatest champions are engaged in the **one contest** no one has ever won.

Sport has always been obsessed with the future. At the start of every season and every tournament, we search for the next great batter, the next dominant footballer, the next athlete capable of redefining the limits of what is possible.

Yet the defining challenge in sport is rarely arrival, but survival.

Talent can take an athlete to the top, but staying there demands dedication and, as the years roll by, an accommodation with time, an opponent that very few have mastered. Despite the arrival of a young Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, some of the IPL's most compelling stories this year belonged to men who had spent years hearing whispers that their best days were behind them.

Bhuvneshwar Kumar, who had last played for India in 2022, was Royal Challengers Bengaluru's most dependable bowler, picking up 28 wickets. Virat Kohli, his beard carrying a little more grey with every passing season, scored 675 runs as RCB secured its second consecutive title. At 37, and only a handful of summers younger than me, he continues to accumulate runs with a consistency that challenges conventional ideas of longevity.

But while the battle with age can be negotiated and delayed, it can never be conquered.

That reality presents itself in different ways. M. S. Dhoni, forever synonymous with Chennai Super Kings, did not take the field in any of CSK's 14 league games this season. Even the most disciplined eventually encounter their limits.

Rohit Sharma's recent years have been punctuated by similar reminders. The runs and match-winning innings still arrive, but increasingly so do conversations around workload, fitness and recovery.

Across the sporting world, the story is much the same. Novak Djokovic's shock Roland Garros defeat to Joao Fonseca, a player 19 years his junior, was a recognition of that reality. The margins that once seemed permanently tilted in his favour are no longer as wide. Time has not defeated Djokovic, but it has made him human.

Ageing athletes force us to confront something we would rather avoid. We celebrate youth because it represents possibility, but we admire longevity because it reminds us that possibility is finite.

Every great athlete reaches a point where the battle is no longer against opponents, but against time. The challenge, from then on, is less about improving and more about preserving.

Football has existed for nearly two decades in the age of Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo. Alongside them, the likes of Luka Modric, Neymar and Manuel Neuer have continued to stretch the limits of what an elite football career can look like. It is difficult to remember a FIFA World Cup without them.

Yet for Messi, Ronaldo, Modric and Neuer, this edition may well be their last.

Messi remains capable of moments that alter matches and moods, while Ronaldo continues to score goals at a prolific rate, albeit in leagues perceived to be less demanding than the rigours of top European competitions.

Eventually, time arrives for everyone, even those who appear capable of outrunning it.

Football is already preparing for what comes next. Lamine Yamal, Erling Haaland, Jude Bellingham and a host of others stand ready to inherit the spotlight.

Yet we still hope Messi, Ronaldo and Modric will give us one more tournament, one more season and one more opportunity to hold back the inevitable.